



New Age, NEW

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SACHIN PILOT,
MP, 31

The advantages of being a young politician in India today have a lot to do with how the demographics of India is changing. It's not just about the age, but when you are young, there is a tendency to break away from the baggage of the past and to bring in change. People are looking for new faces to shake up the system. The aspirations today are different from what they were 25 years ago and a young politician is better positioned to connect with those expectations, delivering more than the political class of yesteryear. This is something we have tried to do over the last five years.

When educated young people enter politics, they are able to create a more transparent working atmosphere and bring in greater credibility. This gives a sense of confidence to the people that here is a new generation that will forge ahead and not get bogged down by archaic issues such as religion, caste, language and ethnicity that have been the driving forces of Indian politics for the last few decades. It is important to be able to carry along all sections of society so that a sense of alienation doesn't creep into some of us. The people of India have great confidence that we can create a new India, an India where the divisions of the past can be surmounted. And the young can be the agents of this change.

It may sound self-congratulatory, but it is the Congress, the oldest party in the country, that was the first to bring the young to the frontlines of politics in India. Today the focus is on the youth, but six years ago when no political party had the courage or the conviction to give tickets to first-time politicians, it was the Congress that ushered many young faces into Parliament and state assemblies. The most visible symbol of change is Rahul Gandhi. He is reaching out to the young and they are easily able to identify with him. In 2003, when I was not an MP, some of us were called to meet Sonia Gandhi and she asked us about the issues that would impact the youth and what the young people wanted from the

Congress. These suggestions were then included in the party manifesto. She said that since you are young, you will better understand the perspective of the tens of millions of young people. I began campaigning for the party even before I fought my first election.

As more and more young people join the political process and take on leadership roles, it will redefine the political landscape of this country. With all the energy, creativity, initiative and imagination that the young are directing to politics and public life, I am sure we can build a nation that will be the envy of the world. To tap into the aspirations of the youth and channelise these into the mainstream is really the challenge of the day. Who can deliver this better than one of them? *as told to Priya Sahgal*

**POLITICAL PARTIES NEED YOUNG LEADERS TO
MAKE THEMSELVES MORE RELEVANT TO THE YOUTH**

